

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

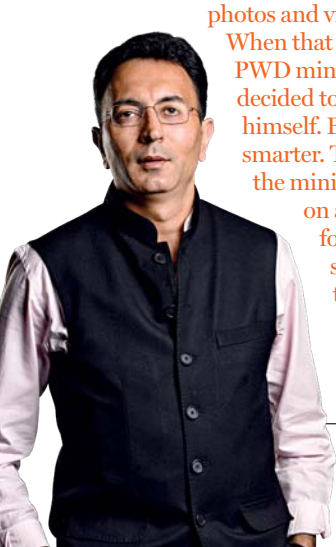
GLASSHOUSE

SISTER ACT

Trust Didi or elder sister Mamata Banerjee to forgive her erring brethren. Thus it was that veteran party leader Mukul Roy, who had fallen out of favour when he was with the BJP between 2017 and 2021, got invited to the West Bengal chief minister's Bhai Phonta ceremony. As was Sovan Chatterjee, another turncoat who flirted with the saffron side for a brief period. Mamata had once dubbed them *gaddars* or traitors, but now seems to have allowed them re-entry into her inner circle. Is there scope then for the other turncoat, Suvendu Adhikari, currently with the BJP, to find similar rehabilitation should he wish to return to the TMC?

Mind the Potholes

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has recently issued directions to roll out a special campaign to make the state's roads *gaddha-mukt* or pothole-free. He has even set a deadline—November 15. Following the announcement, not only the Opposition but several BJP MLAs too started sending officials photos and videos of potholed roads. When that did not elicit any action, PWD minister **Jitin Prasada** decided to go on a reality check himself. But the officials proved smarter. They started contacting the minister's office for tip-offs on areas he is likely to go to for "surprise inspections" so that they can fix the potholes before his arrival. There's no fixing the potholes of the mind, is there?



VIKRAM SHARMA

ADVERTISING HIS OWN CAUSE

On October 31, Madhya Pradesh residents woke up to a full-page ad in local dailies by ex-minister and Vijayraghavgarh BJP MLA **Sanjay Pathak**. The occasion being his birthday, the ad showcased Pathak's philanthropic work in his constituency and the electorate's regard for his family. The mining tycoon had joined the BJP from the Congress in 2014 and rewarded with a ministerial berth. But when the party resumed power in 2020, he wasn't in the cabinet. With a reshuffle likely before the assembly polls in 2023, is Pathak throwing hints?





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Rajasthan chief minister **Ashok Gehlot** these days can be seen dining at Indira Rasois, where one can have a meal for Rs 8, the government subsidising Rs 17. With a Rs 14 crore budget, 870 such kitchens are already running; the number is expected to go up to 1,000 by March. Gehlot has urged local leaders to have meals here too, both to bond with fellow diners and check quality. Self-help groups have been roped in to run the *rasois*. Incidentally, Gehlot's slogan to serve meals respectfully is borrowed from predecessor Vasundhara Raje's mobile Annapurna *rasois*. He had stopped the scheme first, only to realise perhaps that the way to the electorate's heart is via their stomachs.



Jumping the Gun

Following his meeting with Telugu Desam Party chief N. Chandrababu Naidu, Jana Sena Party founder and actor-turned-politician **Pawan Kalyan** got an invite from BJP chief J.P. Nadda to come to Delhi. Despite being told not to strike early poll alliances, PK, as the actor is known, is set to conduct Janavani, a public audit of CM Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy's government, in 26 districts. As a counter, Jagan Mohan will hold district-wise meetings with all 139 cohorts of the Backward Classes to reiterate YSRCP's commitment to them.

Kaushik Deka *with* ***Romita Datta, Rohit Parihar, Prashant Srivastava, Rahul Noronha and Amarnath K. Menon***